Not that he was categorically opposed to compliments. One day, almost in passing, he said that I appeared to lack any…fear. *You're not terribly concerned, if I may say, Lieutenant Wales, with dying.*

That's true.

I explained that I hadn't been afraid of death since the age of twelve.

He nodded once. He got it. We moved on.

34.

NIGE EVENTUALLY RELEASED ME, set me free like a wounded bird restored to health, and with his certification the Army pronounced me ready to fly Apaches.

But nope—it was a trick. I wasn't going to fly Apaches. I was going to sit in a windowless classroom and *read* about Apaches.

I thought: Could anything be crueler? Promise me a helicopter, hand me a stack of homework?

The course lasted three months, during which I nearly went insane. Every night I'd slump back to my cell-like room in the officers' mess and vent to a mate on the phone, or else to my bodyguard. I considered leaving the course altogether. I'd never even wanted to fly Apaches, I said to everyone, petulantly. I wanted to fly the Lynx. It was simpler to learn, and I'd get back to the war faster. But my commanding officer, Colonel David Meyer, quashed that idea. *Not a chance, Harry.*

Why, Colonel?

Because you've had operational ground experience in reconnaissance, you were a very fine FAC, and you're a bloody good pilot. You're going to fly Apaches.

But—

I can tell from the way you fly, the way you read the ground, this is what you were meant to do.